LOCAL INITIATIVES TO IMPROVE SERVICE QUALITY IN A DISTRICT HOSPITAL

Jhenaidah Sadar Hospital

Purpose: Limited human resources and infrastructure are main constraints to effective health service provision at Jhenaidah Sadar Hospital where, like many district hospitals in Bangladesh, a large gap exists between hospital capacity and the community's demand for health services. In such resource-constrained settings, proactive approaches and strong community engagement are necessary for improving service quality and ensuring adequate and equitable access to services, particularly related to maternal and newborn health.

Approach: Proactive leaders within Jhenaidah Sadar Hospital ensured optimum use of existing resources provided by the government by fully engaging the hospital staff and further enlisted the active support of the community, local government, district administration, NGOs, and development partners to mobilize additional funding and human resources to meet the facility's needs.

Positive Change: Jhenaidah Sadar Hospital has seen significant improvements in performance and service quality within a few years. The community is satisfied and supportive of the facility, revenue has increased, the campus is clean and secure, and the 100-bedded hospital performed the highest number of normal vaginal deliveries in Khulna Division in 2014--more so than 250-bedded hospitals.

Jhenaidah Sadar Hospital

photo courtesy of the Guidance GMB Akash

BACKGROUND

Jhenaidah District in southwest Bangladesh has a population of nearly 1.8 million. Jhenaidah Sadar Hospital, the 100-bedded district hospital, is the main center for comprehensive emergency obstetric care (EmOC) in the district. The demand for services at the facility is much greater than can be met by current allocated resources; for instance, while equipped to perform 500 deliveries per year, the maternity department routinely preforms over 2500. Thirty to forty mothers are admitted everyday, yet there are only 5 EmOC beds allocated by the government. By 2014, the hospital's occupancy rate had reached 180%. Even as demand for services increased over many years, there remained only one post for a consultant in obstetrics and gynecology, and one in anesthesiology, but no posts for medical officers in either department.

In March 2011, the Bangladesh Public Administration Training Center (BPATC) began providing technical assistance to Jhenaidah Sadar Hospital to implement a "5S-CQI-TQM" program for quality improvement within the hospital. However, after the first year of encouraging the process, few improvements had been made. With a change in hospital authority in May 2012, the program took off under new leadership. Taking a proactive approach to reforming the hospital service system through local initiatives and enlisting the aid of a strong community support system to provide additional human resources and infrastructure upgrades, the hospital saw tremendous improvements by 2013. The hospital is now among the best performing district hospitals in Khulna Division, having the highest number of normal vaginal deliveries (NVD) and the second highest number of total deliveries in 2014.

WHAT IS 5S-CQI-TQM?

3-step quality improvement tool useful in resource-constrained settings; supported in Bangladesh by the Japan International Cooperation Agency (JICA) and DGHS

"5S" refers to five components of work environment improvement that lead to improved staff satisfaction: Sort, Set, Shine, Standardize, and Sustain

"CQI" (continuous quality improvement) refers to a participatory problem solving approach by hospital staff

"TQM" refers to the Total Quality Management program of the Hospital Section under Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS)

Storeroom neatly organized according to the "5S-Continuous Quality Improvement" method

photo: Save the Children/GMB Akash

PROACTIVE LEADERSHIP IN ADDRESSING CHALLENGES

Upon being posted as Senior Consultant in Obstetrics and Gynecology at Jhenaidah Sadar Hospital in May 2012, Dr. Md. Emdadul Haque recognized that the environment was not conducive to providing quality healthcare services. Beyond constraints in human resources, the facility was dilapidated, stench filled the wards, staff were harassed at night by miscreants on campus, and cows grazed on the grounds among patients. He realized that the hospital would not gain importance in the community unless it was more inviting to staff and patients. With the vision of turning Jhenaidah Sadar Hospital into a model district hospital, the Senior Consultant took action steps to mobilize local support.

"You have to have good intentions, vision, good planning, and concrete action steps. Whatever I want to do it has to be clear and everyone needs to be motivated. It is quite possible to succeed in our efforts no matter how small or big the extent of the work is, if we follow these principles."

Civil Surgeon, Jhenaidah

Using data for decision-making

Acknowledging the importance of quality data to direct planning and decision-making, Dr. Emdad conducted a facility survey immediately upon his appointment in 2012, which assessed the current state of services and resources at the hospital. He then compared the data to those he had collected on his own initiative in 1998 while posted for 6 months as a medical officer in Jhenaidah. Hospital authorities used these analyses to identify problem areas and to develop an action plan for improvement. He also instituted improved recordkeeping practices within the obstetric ward, such as introducing ANC cards, admission forms and register, and discharge forms. With a new emphasis on ANC services and increased capability in recordkeeping, the ward began producing monthly reports that were able to demonstrate an eight-fold increase in ANC visits from 2011 to 2014.

Obstetric Services at Jhenaidah Sadar Hospital (2011-2014)

Year	ANC Service	Admitted Patients	Type of Delivery			PNC
			NVD	CS	Total	
2011	1354	3906	1912	430	2375	2140
2012	2268	4261	1828	551	2379	2467
2013	7096	5445	1811	985	2796	3806
2014	10811	6095	1945	941	2886	3729

Dr. Emdad at a health education session in the hospital

Photo: Save the Children/GMB Akash

Setting an example through positive action

Believing that small incremental improvements lead to larger development as people witness change and become motivated to participate, Dr. Emdad began in his own obstetric ward—setting it as a model that could be replicated across the facility once the community and other doctors were convinced of the process. He equipped the obstetric ward with a telephone and began funding the call credit to facilitate communication among staff during obstetric emergencies. He also enlisted the support of the Civil Surgeon to repair and repaint discarded hospital beds to increase the ward's capacity, encouraged patients to bring their own rexine (coated, wipeable cloth) during deliveries so beds would not become soiled, instituted daily health education sessions, advocated for the construction of additional washrooms, and rearranged the pre-labor and labor room layouts for improved efficiency. The example of his tireless work ethic compelled other obstetric ward staff to go beyond their duty to ensure they were meeting the needs of their patients.

"There is too much workload on all of us. We are under a lot of pressure. Everyone used to say, "Sir we can't do this," but now everyone does it. If nobody would stay on, he would stay all by himself. Now if he can do his part, we can't just say no!"
Senior Staff Nurse

"I do not want to see these institutions depending on any one person. I would like to institutionalize the changes. Small developments such as having an emergency department, having a display of essential information, beautification—these are small steps but are much appreciated by the community."
Senior Consultant, Obs. & Gyn., Jehnaidah Sadar Hospital

"Some just take the easy way out and do not want to get involved in solving any problems. And then some see challenges as opportunities and want to overcome them. He accepted the challenge and convinced others to perceive this as an opportunity. If people trust you, they will extend support to whatever you do and that is the main driving force. People can see that he is not self-centered. People see him do so much that they also feel motivated to do their part." *Deputy Commissioner, Jhenaidah*

Upon witnessing *ayas* accepting bribe money from patients, Dr. Emdad took immediate action to prohibit the practice. He vowed to manage funds to pay *ayas* a regular and legal salary to keep them from relying on bribes. When he began paying out of his own pocket, other doctors, local government officers, administration, and socially conscious community members were motivated and came forward to donate regularly.

"The strength of the leaders here are that they are honest people. If you are honest then you will have courage, and you can do any kind of work. People respect and value an honest person and fear to do anything against them. If Dr. Emdad conducted c-sections in a private clinic outside of the government hospital, then patients would think that he intentionally refers mothers to a private clinic. But he is doing the opposite. He encourages the private clinic patients to come to the Sadar Hospital. He assures the patient better treatment without any cost." *Mayor, Jhenaidah Pouroshabha*

"Dr. Emdad works tirelessly. He has an assistant – Abdur Rahman, who is an anesthesiologist. He is also like Dr. Emdad. If he is summoned even at midnight, he won't hesitate. No matter what time a patient goes, be it during the day or 3:00 am, he is there with Dr. Emdad. When people know that there is someone like him in the hospital, then they won't wonder at 5 in the morning if the doctor is available and go to the private clinic instead."
Deputy Commissioner, Jhenaidah

"Dr. Emdad is never cross with the patients. He never loses his temper and always addresses his patients as *Ma* ("Mother") during each delivery."
Senior Staff Nurse

photo: Save the Children/GMB Akash

Community engagement

Members of local community organizations have been active in supporting Jhenaidah Sadar Hospital for several years. Upon Dr. Emdad's appointment, he sought out these interested individuals and worked to engage further support from local government authorities (e.g. Mayor), the local MP, district administrators (Deputy Commissioner, Social Welfare Officer, etc.), media, human rights organizations, social workers, cultural activists, businessmen, and local professors. Seizing every opportunity to meet with stakeholders and using facility data to inform them about pressing public health issues, community needs, and the constraints faced by the hospital, Dr. Emdad was able to motivate individuals to take shared ownership of the situation.

"You will never overcome by pursuing only power and authoritarianism. Counseling and motivating the people is the big thing here. Emdad bhai is able to convince people successfully in Jhenaidah, and he can do this because he has the mentality to serve the people. If he were a businessmen or a heartless person then it will not be possible. Our new Hospital Superintendent is also following this approach to motivating people."

Mayor, Jhenaidah Pouroshabha

"I was very surprised the doctor proactively met with us [at a Shilpakala Academy cultural event]. When we got off the stage, Dr. Emdad came and introduced himself. He mentioned that he was the area's Gyn consultant and invited us to visit the hospital. I wondered why he came there and met with us. We usually chase them, right? We started inquiring about him and found out what kind of a person he was."

Cultural activist and teacher

With Dr. Emdad's encouragement, the newly posted Civil Surgeon took the initiative to begin daily visits to the facility to check if ceiling fans and water supplies were working and trash was removed, the District Health Improvement Committee headed by the MP was reactivated, hospital staff began meeting regularly to discuss quality of care issues, and a local businessman responded to requests for support by donating an emergency generator to allow surgeries without power interruptions. Most importantly, funds have been mobilized from community sources to support small salaries for 51 non-government volunteers in the facility to fill human resource gaps (e.g. nurse assistants, guard, gardener, ward boys, trolly pushers, cleaners, *ayas*, etc.). Community leaders in Jhenaidah insist that there are people in every community across the country who want to similarly donate funds for the betterment of their society, but are inhibited due to poor trust that institutions will use the money honestly. In Jhenaidah, community-donated funds are deposited directly into the bank, limiting chances of mishandling by middlemen. Supporters regularly visit the hospital, observe tangible improvements resulting from their donations, and remain motivated to continue their support.

"The Mayor, community organizations, our doctors started donating. Then everyone came forward. They saw that their donations are not wasted. The hospital was clean. They all realized that this is our hospital. That is why they all contributed."

Civil Surgeon, Jhenaidah

Community-supported trolley men now work in the hospital

photo: Save the Children/©ATM Akash

A BIG CLEANING DAY

On 17th March 2015, the hospital celebrated its first "Big Cleaning Day," during which hospital staff and administration, local leaders, and government officials participated in a deep cleaning of the hospital and grounds. This event will continue to be held every third month.

photo: Jhenaidah Sadar Hospital

Mohammad Shafikul Islam, Deputy Commissioner

Dr. Reza Sekendar, Hospital Superintendent

Local leaders supportive of the hospital actively participated in cleaning the campus during the "Big Cleaning Day"

Saidul Karim Mintu, Mayor, Jhenaidah Pouroshabha

photos: Save the Children/GMB Akash

Dr. Mohammad Abdul Salam, Civil Surgeon, Jhenaidah

photo: Save the Children/GMB Akash

INNOVATING TO OVERCOME CHALLENGES

Hospital Information Center

Patients and their attendants struggled to get admission and service information quickly upon reaching Jhenaidah Sadar Hospital, which resulted in delays in receiving proper care. To address this, Dr. Emdad approached community leaders and requested them to expand their existing support. A wealthy businessman responded to the proposal, providing funds to build an Information Center at the entrance to the hospital in addition to supporting the salary of a non-government worker to serve patients in the Information Center. Patients can now have their questions answered quickly and be directed to the right places in the facility to meet their needs. Furthermore, patients' lab results can be collected at the Information Center during after-hours.

Cycle stand

Previously, bicycles and motorcycles were parked haphazardly around the hospital campus. With no security system in place, chaos would repeatedly erupt at the hospital when cycles were stolen. Hospital authority and a former Chairman of Jhenaidah Pouroshabha came forward to renovate a cycle stand on campus and outsource its management to a local community group. In addition to improving the hospital's environment, the stand has become a source of income generation. Earnings generated from the stand are used to support poor patients and the development of the hospital mosque.

photo: Save the Children/GMB Akash

photo: Save the Children/GMB Akash

Maintaining easily observable doctor roster and Citizens' Charter

Jhenaidah Sadar Hospital maintains a doctor roster in the corridor of the hospital so patients and their attendants can easily find information about doctors on duty for increased accountability. To further ensure patients have easy access to information, Dr. Emdad advocated for the renovation of a large painting of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare's Citizen's Charter on the outside wall of the facility.

Intercom system for improved communication

To facilitate easier communication among hospital staff and thus improve efficiency of services, Dr. Emdad advocated for the installation of an intercom system throughout the facility. Having built such strong relationships within the community, his requests were quickly fulfilled by a local industrialist who donated the intercom system.

Directly enlisting support from development partners

Having witnessed the work of Japan International Cooperation Agency (JICA)'s Total Quality Management (TQM) activities under the Safe Motherhood Promotion Project Phase 2 (SMPP-2) in other facilities, Dr. Emdad took the initiative to motivate authorities at JICA and Directorate General Health Services (DGHS) to expand the reach of SMPP-2 to include Jhenaidah Sadar Hospital. In response, a JICA volunteer was posted at the hospital to facilitate Quality Improvement Teams and Work Improvement Teams and a learning visit was organized for a 15-member delegation from Jhenaidah Sadar Hospital to observe Satkhira District Hospital where SMPP-2 was active. This learning visit catalyzed attitude changes in hospital officers and staff and inspired them to promote improvements at Jhenaidah Sadar Hospital.

ACHIEVEMENTS AND POSITIVE CHANGE

» Active community participation
- MP, Mayor, local government, and community members including doctors of the hospital provide salaries for over 50 non-government hospital volunteer staff; contribute furniture and regular maintenance support
- District Health Improvement Committee reactivated

» Improved performance of obstetrics program
- Highest number of NVD and 2nd highest in total deliveries in Khulna Division
- Instituted ANC, PNC, and breastfeeding support services
- Provided privacy curtains
- Increased number of EmOC beds from 5 to 21
- Instituted shoe-free environment in operating room and improved infection control system

» Improved cleanliness and beautification of facility and campus
- Instituted waste management system and regular cleaning of drainage system
- Removed all unnecessary posters from walls
- Brought storerooms into order and neatly labeled all supplies
- Repaired campus boundary wall
- Created gardens for campus beautification

» Improved security
- Guards employed for 24/7 security

» Improved financial management
- Comparative data between August 2013 and August 2014 show an increase in total facility revenue from BDT 3.1 lakh to 5.5 lakh

"The biggest improvement is the environment. People are convinced they are in good hands. If we don't provide good services to the people, then our source of income will become uncertain, so the staff are convinced and willing to help. There seems to be a healthy competition to top each other's performance. If I am acknowledged as a hard worker and people are satisfied with my service, then that gives me self-contentment. We want to establish the hospital as a noble institution."

Deputy Commissioner, Jhenaidah

photo: Save the Children/GMB Akash

"The patients of Jhenaidah will make sure that this tradition continues in the absence of Dr. Emdad Sir. I firmly believe the public will make sure to keep it maintained what has been started. Even if doctors do not want to, the public will insist on it."

Senior Staff Nurse

KEYS TO SUCCESS

Holistic approach to health care: Dr. Emdad identifies as a public health specialist and development worker more than a clinician. He credits foundation training in development economics and public health as pivotal in shaping his philosophies and equipping him with the knowledge of how to select appropriate indicators for development and the importance of collecting quality data for use in strategy design. Emphasizing a holistic approach to health, he places importance on health education, preventative approaches to protect health, and networking with stakeholders across every sector.

Personal mastery: Dr. Emdad's integrity and strong work ethic has allowed him to lead by example and convince stakeholders to share in his vision for establishing a model district hospital. Rather than leading through exhibitions of power and authority, Dr. Emdad sees success because of his honest approach to information sharing and sincere concern for the community's needs.

Viewing challenges as opportunities: Fostering a positive work environment and seeing challenges as opportunities while taking small, incremental steps towards improvement rather than waiting only for increased government allocations led to a snowball effect in engaging staff and community. Observing incremental, tangible improvements at the facility builds the trust of hospital supporters (e.g. donors, volunteers, staff, and local officials), who then gain confidence to continue offering support.

Using data to motivate people for action: Dr. Emdad's successful partnership building for the hospital has been facilitated by his relentless sharing of facility data. Sharing concrete information about local health needs and the limited available resources with everyone from teachers, to government officials, and the media enables him to make a strong case for the need for strong community support of the hospital.

"I am working for the development of the whole country, not only as a gynecologist or a health worker, but as a development worker. When I speak to the community, I speak about holistic development. I link primary education, agriculture, and many other sectors to motivate them. Nutrition is linked to agriculture and without education, how can we prevent early marriage or encourage family planning?"

Senior Consultant (Obs & Gyn), Jhenaidah Sadar Hospital

photo: Save the Children/Shafiq Alam

A community-supported cleaner sweeps the facility

RECOMMENDATIONS

1. Strong foundational training in public health, development, and strategic leadership can benefit all clinicians serving in the public healthcare system when offered early in their careers.

2. Provisions should be made to facilitate visits for hospital authorities and staff to observe model facilities and witness firsthand how strong leadership, community engagement, and innovation can result in sustained improvements in service provision quality. Facility tours and discussions with facility leaders, local officials, social workers, and volunteers could provide inspiration to health workers, and encourage them to transfer innovations to their own facilities.

3. The concept of volunteerism should be further fostered. Hospitals authorities should work to leverage support from interested community volunteers who benefit by gaining valuable hands-on experience in health service activities while contributing to the betterment of their community.

FURTHER EXPLORATION

Additional lessons in strong leadership and community-supported quality improvement of government health facilities may be learned from Dr. Emdad's well-known Chowgacha Model in Bangladesh. Beyond this, there are other initiatives that could provide beneficial insights, such as:

- Horizontal Learning Program (World Bank)
- Tangail District Hospital's experience with Total Quality Management

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